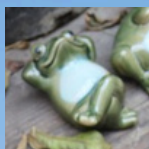
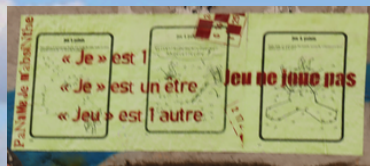


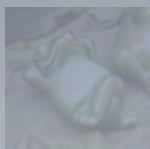
Modes of Displacement



Chapbook By Coco Zhang

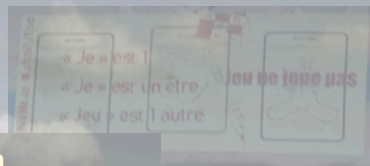


Content



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Post-Rejection To-Do



Wonderer's Guide to Boston

take the red line over longfellow bridge with marble balustrade
shaped to be leaned on
the skyline uncovers itself and shies away before you piece
together the camera,
the train only spares mercy for the eyes, and you spot the sole
duck tour drifting
on a tuesday morning, while your mind lingers among friends
chattering
about love and job and together you endure frantic, endless swipes
for both, the same two-sided coin of adulthood, where you now sit
between people you not yet know with a book you're not
reading, instead you peer obsessively outside the scratched
window
for a hint, a story, someone, or something

shiny, the river has scales and shivers in the slow spring like a tin
man
when you come close to the crisp waves and even closer to be at
eye-level
with it, you have taken several long exhales to leave subway air
behind
then the same hand that held metal handrails and pressed for
crosswalk signals
reaches out to feel the vibrating sternum of a horse, 17-year-old
boston park ranger,
Franklin park native trekking his way to the commons, for
commoners
like picnickers and runners, breathe in the smell of dried grass,
the statics building up before a little downpour, so you have to get
up
with marks in your palm and wet straws damping your jeans and
stand
shamelessly blocking the road, still look and look into the
blossoming horizon

the copley, the newbury, the audacious capital one cafe await
preachers for jesus and skateboarders auditioning to be added
to pratt's allegories
science and art, oxidized bronze returning the greenness to the
women's wreaths
flaunt your legitimate presence, grip on to the unread poetry
even harder
remember your many human qualities in the blank street line
those you haven't lost to the majestic american origin story. It's
perfectly fine to
hate this part of the walk anyways it's the coda

for a wonderous wander and its wanderers, if only you can drift
more
take the orange line (favorite mbta line) to forest hill
to third cliff cafe (amazing kimchi croissants for anyone yet to
try them)
to yeti sandwiches and obscenely-sized chips (forgot the
restaurant's name)
to harvard arboretum (unbelievable right spelling at first shot)
then you can sit and dream on the bench that overlooks the city
and wander in your dream a bit more

Race to the Sea

Big squirrel debates never explained your obsessive aggression
Jeju years never rid you of the seasickness
Have you found your way home?

battling the squeaky growls of towering sheep gates
tracing the mush we made stumping over wild garlics
sneaking pass teenagers chucking beers in sunken trenches

If I knock at your door,
will you be old and grown,
old enough to catch up with
my speedy nostalgia so we race
over the stinging nettles
through the Cambodian harvest
down the rocky cliffs

then will you dip your tail in the waves
so I will join you in the salty Atlantic
saltier than I'd ever let your doggy bowl taste

– To Fenris, Ahlya's Jeju Stray Boy



Daisies in London

let's go window shopping
when the night captures every waterfront highrise
we can pick a life together
and try not to haul the self-checkout with squabbles

we study street wisdom on my carpet over kensington
play camouflage as those who sneer at every motorcyclist tantrum
and march around barricades of borgeoise white
the rule is to always take the first left but never circle back

we live in a spin-off utopia or maybe it's just a
merry-go-round that made two-year-old you cry
eyes wide open and dazed by growing vertigo
don't stop – the city drowns us in its endless dreams

Your chest rose
and fall with my silence
breathing through you,
a hyperventilated,
howling elephant.

Thousand miles across the continent,
we travel just for the burial of
our shaved buzz,
our young blood,
the stars that shied away at our laughs
before they're dulled by the bills and taxes

I carry you with me,
soft brunette and pretty voice
where I get lost in its melting violets.
and we migrate through
our private language.

I abuse every signifier
to squeeze your being from
my barren mind.
It bears no power
to your frame,
to frame
you
always matter over mind.

Khawaja's Dream

Seven days I press my feet into the cool concrete
sneak under the bug nets you hung so carefully
shielding us from blackout and drought,
a storm drones up and down thinning walls.
Baby screams. We coo her, hold her,
praise her custom gowns — What's her name?
KimbAaly, our tongues raised Aaa

Seven days our English takes on stubborn battles
because I don't speak Kakwa and
my Arabic never lasts over a minute.
You teach me again and again —
Anamingoni.

I repeat it over and over till the van tumbles off.
Chinese whispers till it's just sounds.
I see you again? We will meet again? Nothing
fetches my misplaced vowels and teases my tears
when it soaks the back of your best shirt.

Seven days later, I am left with a souvenir
elephant, more WhatsApp numbers than
I can bring myself to text, and
patterned fabric all over my wall reminds me that
you never made my dress out of it.

Seven days and seven days, I find your voicemail
with drunken swears in my inbox.
sorry that your boss held you over the weekend
sorry for missing you so much but never writing back
sorry for arriving just to leave, flocking around
self-conceited patrons with throwaway numbers.

Seven days and seven days and a new year, rain returns
and persists to smooth the crackled roads.
Your day-long journey to Kampala
must be less bumpy, cassavas must be growing
on your plates, boda bodas must be splashing
around the streets and the Khawajas must leave.

Would you believe I wish I stayed?

Philosophising the Abstract

important elements for you to write a meaningful allegory like a white male:

there is a cave where people are stashed away, all but a philosophy king who is the pensive hero and the anti-hero who kills other thoughts. the best of both worlds, truly

there is fire, which makes it an eulogy. all hail to heroes in the story and the hero who writes it for bringing fire around and now everyone can have a bite on prometheus

there is a wall, not those bulges between tectonic plates, not those barriers keeping people away from others not so different, not even those barricades you can mount in a great war. it's a wall, a formally perfect one, so frustratingly perfect that humpty dumpty dare not mess up and fall off from

there are shadows, masking everyone's face so we don't see color, masking everyone's body, so you don't see genitals and whatever they say or not say. if you're curious like me, you persist and stare into the blobs of shades until your eyes become sore and watery. only then you realise: everyone melts into a perfect form dazzling pale with the fire

smile and wave, readers, smile and wave as you're at the picture wall for being in this perfect fluid mix smelling of humanity

Post-Rejection To-Do

A minute and an hour at a time
a tic and a tac and a toe below

Break up one American suburb from another
Spot blue pedals crouching along patches of green
or astigmatic streetlights like stars atop christmas trees
Sled down the last pile of ice in our world of winding spring
Hang on (call from home)

...

Crack open the bag of granola with no yogurt nor milk
Sit in detergent smelling staircases as life leaks out
and cry and cry and until it oozes back in cry
Soak those broken pipes in your lungs with bogo deal groceries
Open camera (set ratio 16:9)

Dust off existential literature you never touched
Set out for bland latte from the average chains
amongst people with hustles, even a dream apartment
Slip into the same graphic tee to knock on neighbors' doors
Move out (text roommate)

Every calculator screams the fact:
a day is twenty-four hours and a-thousand-four-hundred-and-
forty minutes.
in a second (open calculator)

Acknowledgement

Thank you to
ENG202 Poetry (S26),
for a semester
full of open
hearts and
beautiful lyrics



special thanks to
Professor Dan Chiasson
and Cindy Li, who sent me the syllabus
for the class and got me on this journey

Nataie Ng, for
reading my poems
at random hours



Alice Suppiah, for maybe
reading them as she receives the
same files but takes longer to reply,
love you, my Londoner

The dull winter and the slow spring have turned this semester into a
true rollercoaster that suddenly halts as I scuffle through those
words I put together over the past four months.



Dear Coco, you are still mid-air, but you
made it through another one, perhaps
the toughest one so far. You're going to:
Welcome another summer

